

Impact of Rohingya influx on host community's relations to places in Bangladesh

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ABSTRACT

This article assesses the 'relations to place' of the communities neighboring the Rohingya camps in Bangladesh. In doing so, two qualitative data collection methods (FGD and in-depth interview) were applied in the neighboring communities that focused on their place relations (i.e., sense of place, place utility, place attachment, place dependence, place identity, and place obduracy). The results show how the unprecedented influx of Rohingyas negatively influences their relations with the places. Therefore, this paper proposes further studying the complexity of place relations in the host communities, which may contribute to future policy planning concerning Rohingyas in Bangladesh.

Introduction

No one wants to leave their home without having a worthy cause, but there are times when people abandon everything and leave their place of residence. Due to an extremely disastrous event or a war, people usually lose their homes to stay in and struggle with earning opportunities to run the family. In such a condition, people forcibly migrate from their favorite abode and seek shelter elsewhere (Klepp, 2017; Fair, 2018). Likewise, in September 2017, 1.1 million Rohingya (Rakhine) came to Bangladesh from Arakan province in Myanmar, and were unable to endure riots and atrocities governed by the police and military of Myanmar (Policy Research Institute, 2018; Ahmed, 2019; Bowden, 2018; de Chickera, 2018; Kangkun & Quinley, 2018). Thousands of children, the elderly and female Rohingya continued to enter Ukhia and Teknaf regions through the South-East corner of Bangladesh. The Bangladeshi government stood by these homeless people, came forward to assist them, and took the initiative to provide security to them. Later on, the government of Bangladesh slowly transferred most of the Rohingyas to the camp (Livingston et al., 2019; Wencel et al., 2018). With the help of foreign agencies and initiatives, the government of Bangladesh still provides nourishment and security to this large population (Save the Children, 2018; Bowden, 2018; Wencel et al., 2018). Also, through meetings and campaigns with various diplomatic, foreign and international agencies, the government of Bangladesh has been making concerted efforts to send back the Rohingyas to Myanmar. Still, it has not happened. Therefore, the government of Bangladesh has undertaken many shelter projects for the Rohingyas in Ukhia and Teknaf, and a sizeable Rohingya camp was built on Bhasanchar Island (Ahmed, 2019; Marsh, 2019).

The arrival of the Rohingyas was very unexpected for the host communities. Suddenly, a change occurred in their usual way of living due to thousands of unidentified people, orphans, children, women, and older adults. Besides, many local and foreign aid organizations have gathered in the region with various projects that also influence the livelihood of the host communities. During the last three years, the area has undergone an enormous change in the social, political, economic, and natural environment (Wencel et al.,

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2018). Notably, in the host communities, a few had improved their financial conditions, but many became more miserable. Some have sent their children away to the city for education, and some have stopped attending school. Some were forced to migrate due to a shortage of income, and some took responsibility for their families after taking new jobs in the Rohingya camps (Khan, 2018; Banik, 2018).

So it is crucial to know how many such changes in social, political, economic, and environmental conditions are significant for their relations to the place of the host communities (Ansar & Khaled, 2021). Unexpectedly, the local people may relocate to avoid the unexpected consequences to their lives due to the Rohingya influx. Several organizations have mentioned studying the living conditions of the host communities but still lack any specific initiative (Save the Children, 2018).

Given all these situations, this study assesses the relations to the place of the host communities. Six essential characteristics can be understood as links to an individual's place: place dependence, place attachment, place identity, place utility, sense of place, and place obduracy. Based on an empirical study that includes in-depth interviews and focus group discussions with the respondents from host communities, this study focuses on what conditions the host communities perceive about their future living with Rohingya refugees at their present places.

Literature review

Sense of place

Individual's physical and emotional bondage toward a place is called the sense of place (Tapsuwan et al., 2011). This sense of place is time bounded (Nicolosi & Corbett, 2018). Individuals, society, and place are intertwined (Parkhill et al., 2011). The motivation of individuals and communities to make sustainable places is influenced by their connection to place (Acedo et al., 2017). Place attachment motivates care relationships and stewardship between people and their environments (Ardoin, 2014; Buta et al., 2014). In this way, volunteer groups play an essential role in creating deeper societal or mindset shifts.

Place utility

Place utility is the satisfaction or dissatisfaction of an individual concerning their place, which would be either positive or negative (Wolpert, 1965). Individuals make migration decisions only when they experience residential dissatisfaction, and place utility turns negative from its positive condition (Brown & Moore, 1970; Speare, 1974). Positive place utility functions place attachment and place dependence (Adams & Adger, 2013). Place attachment and place dependence focuses on the interplay between the environment in terms of resources and cultural dimensions. Individuals benefit from the environment, such as income generation activities, and form different social and cultural dimensions. Provisioning ecosystem services (i.e., food, fiber, water, fuel etc.) have been emphasized, whereas cultural services have been poorly considered (Rodríguez et al., 2006). Cultural ecosystem services contribute to making place utility and are essential in migration decision-making (Adams & Adger, 2013).

Place attachment

Individuals or groups have emotional connections to their environment in terms of relationships, memories, and aesthetics, called place attachment (Jorgensen & Stedman, 2001). The natural and built environment is essential in forming attachments to places (Stedman, 2003; Kyle et al., 2004). Social life and ties contribute to place attachment (Kohlbacher et al., 2015; Westin, 2016). For instance, the strength of community ties indicates stronger place attachment (Lewicka, 2011). Brehm et al. (2013) found the natural environment in the context of activities (e.g. hunting, hiking, fishing etc.) that involves family, friends, and community. Attachment to place is found to be stronger in individuals who have visited a place often or stayed there for extended periods (Mulvaney et al., 2020). Raymond et al. (2017) explain place attachment as a process that occurs over longer periods and sensory dimensions, for instance, sight, smell, hearing, taste, and touch. Length of residence in a place, or immobility, does not necessarily predict strong place attachment, although dwelling place is often associated with the feelings of 'home' (Westin, 2016). Feelings of 'home' are related to how individuals depend on place. Individuals may frequently migrate to other places for work or family, but they still rely on their residential municipality for their daily services (e.g. school, healthcare etc.).

Place dependence

Place dependence can be described as how well a place allows individuals to perform certain activities (Jorgensen & Stedman, 2001). In human geography, urban planning, and environmental psychology, place dependence focuses on the functional dependence on a place's resources and facilities (Williams & Roggenbuck, 1989). Pretty et al. (2003) define place dependence as satisfying certain aspirational and entertainment needs. Place dependence is what people can do in a place, which they can't do in other places (Mulvaney et al., 2020). Therefore, place dependence includes the perceived ways place provides for an individual's needs and desires (Suntikul & Jachna, 2016). Lower-income workers may strongly rely on a particular site for income, economic opportunities, or affordable living costs. And it does not necessarily indicate strong place dependence, as place dependence is defined by satisfaction and comfortable living or working conditions (Trabka, 2019; Zhu et al., 2021). The fulfillment of needs and desires through interactions with place allows individuals to identify the unique ways a place may provide for them (Trabka, 2019; Wan et al., 2022). Poorer communities, with lower employment rates, informal dwelling places, and little access to electricity, were found to be less 'satisfied'

Palongkhali and Raja Palong Union at Ukhia Upazila

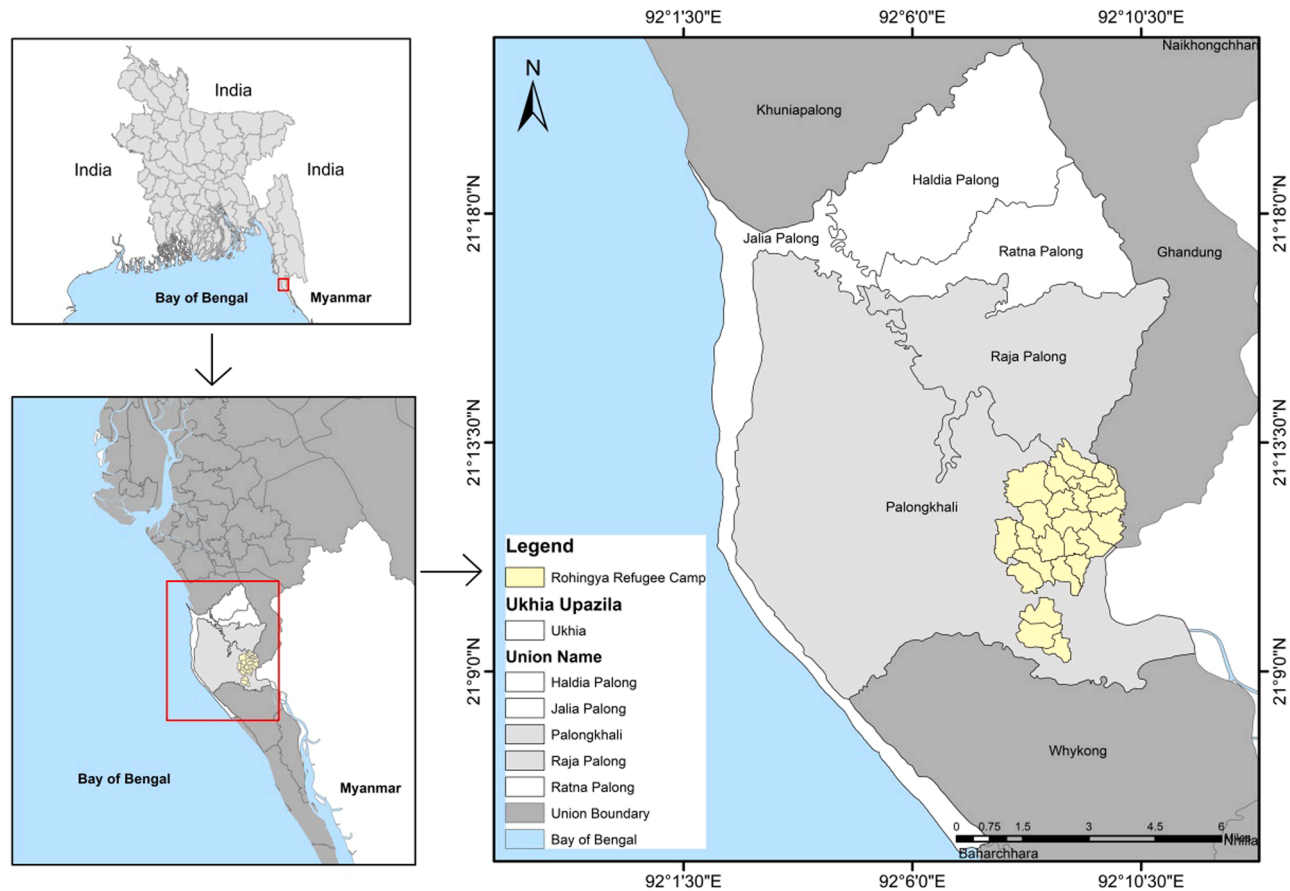


Fig. 1. Study area map Palongkhali and Raja Palong unions associated with the camp.

Source: Author's illustration (data adapted from USGS & Humanitarian Data Exchange ([Humanitarian Data Exchange](https://data.humdata.org/), 2019)).

with the place, expressing a desire to move (Dlamini et al., 2020). Therefore, place dependence has significant social and environmental implications.

Place identity

A person is dependent on a certain place for constructing their identity (Mulvaney et al., 2020). Kyle et al. (2004) operationalized place identity in their research, like, “This place says a lot about who I am” or “This place is a part of me” (p. 446). Place identity can be summed up in this statement, “This place represents or reflects who I am” (Jorgenson & Stedman, 2001, p. 241). Identities are constructed from relationships with the physical environment and highly complex social relations (Allen et al., 2012). Place identity should not be confused with place character or the structures and functions embedded in place (Masterson et al., 2017). The place-based consumption patterns of hipsters are often formed together with the gentrification of neighbourhoods (le Grand, 2020). Place identities also rely on boundaries (Yuval-Davis, 2006). Power presents itself in everyday uses and meanings of place (Manzo & Perkins, 2006). Factors that influence the sense of belonging and participation in a community are gender, sexuality, race, ethnicity, and class (Manzo, 2005). Thus, power dynamics play an important role in individuals’ place identities.

Place obduracy

Place obduracy describes the conditions under which the rate and scale of sociocultural and socioeconomic change lags behind concurrent changes in environmental conditions. We explain “place obduracy as a type of maladaptation in which local place relations create a barrier to migration and, as such, increase the associated risks to people experiencing environmental stress” (Rabbani et al., 2022). A person with certain skills related to their place, for instance, extensive fishing, cannot adopt a new skill quickly (Rabbani et al., 2022).

All these six attributes of relations to place refer to a person’s connection with the geographical location based on the role and characteristics of social memberships (Brown et al., 2019; Raymond et al., 2010). According to Hernández et al. (2010), place identity is the concept of self, which has been developed based on the place where the individual belongs and carries the elements related to the public image of that place. It is a mechanism of self-concept, and it reflects a person’s status where s/he belongs to (Droseltis & Vignoles, 2010). So does Cox’s Bazar community people; their local language, social and family bonding, culture, occupation, hospitality, and voluntary activities differentiate them from the people of other places.

Bonding, bridging, and linking are three types of social capital based on relationships of various connections between actors at different levels (Dahal & Adhikari, 2008). Woolcock and Sweetser (2002) defined bonding, bridging, and linking social capital in their research as “bonding social capital refers to connections to people like you (family, relatives, kinship)” whereas “bridging social capital refers to connections to people who are not like you in some demographic sense,” and “linking social capital pertains to connections with people in power, whether they are in politically or financially influential positions” (p. 26). Bonding social capital is the connection within a homogeneous group and bridging social capital is the relationship among people across diverse social divisions (Field, 2003). Linking social capital includes vertical references to formal institutions (Mayoux, 2001; Woolcock, 2001).

Table 1
Characteristics of the respondents.

Code	Age	Gender	Occupation	Marital Status	Village	Union
I ₁	56	Male	Retailer	Married	Dargah Bil	Raja Palong
I ₂	34	Male	Farmer	Married	Lambaghona	Raja Palong
I ₃	25	Male	Day labourer	Married	Dargah Bil	Raja Palong
I ₄	55	Male	Wood carpenter	Married	Purba Farir Bil	Palongkhali
I ₅	35	Male	Shopkeeper	Married	Kutu Palong	Raja Palong
I ₆	21	Male	Student	Single	Sikdar Bil	Raja Palong
I ₇	15	Male	Student	Single	Falia Para	Raja Palong
I ₈	32	Male	Social worker	Married	Purba Balukhali	Palongkhali
I ₉	45	Female	Housewife	Married	Tutir Bil	Raja Palong
I ₁₀	17	Female	Student	Single	Purba Balukhali	Palongkhali
I ₁₁	35	Male	Businessman	Married	Kutu Palong	Raja Palong
I ₁₂	45	Female	Housewife	Married	Palongkhali	Palongkhali
I ₁₃	40	Male	Farmer	Married	Telkhola	Palongkhali
I ₁₄	36	Female	Housewife	Married	Palongkhali	Palongkhali
I ₁₅	22	Male	Student	Single	Lambaghona	Rajapalong
F ₁	54	Male	Wood carpenter	Married	Falia Para	Raja Palong
F ₂	45	Male	Businessman	Married	Purba Farir Bil	Plongkhali

(N.B.: I_n = Interview participants; F_n = FGD participants)

Methodology

Study sites

The largest Rohingya camps exist in two Upazilas (i.e., sub-district) of Cox Bazar district, namely Ukhia and Teknaf Upazilla (Holloway, 2018). Ukhia Upazila stands in between 21°08' and 21°21' north latitudes and in between 92°03' and 92°12' east longitudes, and it consists of five unions named Jalia Palong, Palongkhali, Ratna Palong, Raja Palong, and Haldia Palong. The average literacy rate in the Ukhia Upazila is 28.4%, which is far below the national average of 72.89%, indicating that most people depend on natural resource-based income opportunities. Likewise, the primary income sources consist of agriculture 54.4%, non-agricultural laborer 10.61% and commerce 15% (BBS, 2012). Data has been collected from the neighboring two unions, namely Palongkhali and Raja Palong host communities of Ukhia Upazila (Fig. 1).

Research design and methods

Using qualitative data collection methods, for instance, Focus Group Discussions (FGDs), and in-depth interviews, this research has identified the place relations of the host communities despite the Rohingya influx. The FGDs mainly focused on the social and environmental changes after the Rohingya influx. The in-depth interview cover questions related to their relations to place after the Rohingya influx in their community and how it has changed their residential satisfaction.

Two focus group discussion sessions were conducted with the local villagers. For each FGD, 10 participants were selected respectively. The FGD participants were middle-aged and elderly adults who could identify the locality changes. A total of fifteen residents from the host communities were interviewed, taking into consideration the people of different occupations. Information about the participants has been enlisted in Table 1 in the results section. By being reflexive and considering the native speaking ability and positionality at every step of the research process, the author ensures production research that enables different forms of knowledge and fairly represents the realities and voices of the study participants.

Data collection and management

In April 2019, the author of this paper conducted both the FGD sessions and the in-depth interviews. All the FGD sessions and in-depth interviews were conducted in Bangla. All the sessions and discussions were recorded upon the consent of the respondents. For conducting FGD, the author hired two research assistants. They were assigned to facilitate group discussion, including arrangement, note-keeping, and reporting. The FGDs focused on exploring the consequences to society and the environment. Mainly, they were asked about changes observed in the societal structures and institutions and residential satisfaction as consequences of the Rohingya influx. FGD session lasted between 90 and 120 min.

The author interviewed the participants in a tea stall, at their homes, or in the park, according to their preferences. Recruiting interviewees was a purposive sampling strategy through the snowballing technique. Firstly, a person participating in the focus group discussion was asked for an interview. In addition, informal conversations with locals helped gain access to future respondents. Data were collected by several informants (i.e., 15 persons for this study) until saturation was achieved; thus, respondents started repeating the same stories, events, and experiences. Validation was made by presenting participants with the opportunity to review how they were quoted and the analysis drawn from their words. An interview lasted 45–60 min.

In the in-depth interviews mainly, they were asked questions related to (i) To what extent had their livelihoods and environmental conditions influenced their place dependence after the Rohingya influx? (ii) Whether were they feeling losing their identity due to Rohingyas? How did they co-exist with the Rohingyas, and what challenges did they face? (iii) Did their living places reflect their wishes, demands, and opportunities? (iv) After the Rohingya influx, did they think they could find themselves at their villages as they did? Did they feel threats to their culture, social bondings, environment, etc.?

Data analysis and interpretation

Later, all the audio recordings of the FGD sessions and the in-depth interviews were transcribed, translated from Bengali to English, and analysed. The author has conducted qualitative data analysis by using software Atlas.ti. To identify the respondents' significant statements, the author read each transcript several times. According to the statements themes, coding was provided, where certain labels were assigned to specific words or phrases from interviews. First, open coding was performed, where common themes across the interviews were identified through a review of the transcripts and interview recordings. Certain themes were identified through concepts related to place relations, while others were emergent. Six types of place relations have already been identified from the literature. The connections have been identified to the various place relation with relevant statements using the codes. Thereafter, axial and selective coding occurred, where codes less relevant to the study's focus were removed. During this process, the remaining codes were promoted to the status of broader categories or themes. Furthermore, the study's findings have been compared to the existing literature.

Ethical concern

This research followed the ethical principles of the Helsinki Declaration, but no institutional review board (IRB) was involved.

However, the purpose of the study was explained to the respondents, and consent was taken before the interview. The respondents had the right to quit the interview at any time. The real identity of the study participants is not used anywhere in the study.

Findings

This study reviews the empirical findings taking these six critical indicators of place relations (sense of place, place utility, place attachment, place dependence, place identity, and place obduracy) into consideration. The following Table 1 shows the characteristics of the study participants.

Sense of place

Host community residents became more concerned about their relations and commitment to their places, i.e. senses of their living places. Usually, their social bonding combines family and friend belongingness that positively impacts their sense of place and residential satisfaction. It creates their holding power of place, where high social bonding represents a notable trend of residential satisfaction and place dependence (Raymond et al., 2010; Ramkissoon & Felix, 2015). Before the Rohingya Influx, there was solid social bonding amongst the host community. A male retailer at Dargah Bil village expressed,

“Before Rohingya people moved freely among the community, people gossiped at the marketplace, youth played at the playground, and neighbours frequently visited nearby households. My friends frequently visited my shop, and we used to spend good quality time with a cup of tea. There were not many noises, as well. But certainly, the scenario became changed. The market is always full of thousands of unknown people, a huge number of national people came to this place for the job for Rohingyas and created extra pressure on our neighbourhoods and social culture” (I₁).

Playground seems almost empty because most youths are engaged in economic activities instead of physical exercise or study. Neighbours and friends did not come frequently to visit where else most of them were busy with other activities. Young people previously seemed to do some volunteer activities. Still, now they are doing either jobs in the refugee crisis or acting as vendors that make them economically solvent but what about social bonding? A male respondent from Lambaghona village said,

“We enjoyed many sports events in the playground last time. But everything has changed after the Rohingya influx. Now we do not have much social gathering. I am afraid we lose our community feel” (I₁₅).

It depicts the disappointment of the changes in the social environment due to Rohingyas. Most of the interviewed people narrated similar opinions. They mentioned that if there were no strong relationships with family and friends, they would have to move to another place to live. However, they were trying to believe more strong social bonding amongst family and friends; they could overcome the crisis due to Rohingyas and live in peace with what they had before. But they did not have any specific plan of action thereof. Even they fear unexpected changes in their socioeconomic and environmental conditions due to ongoing humanitarian activities and development programs for the Rohingyas, which neglected their chances of getting support instead, it caused price hikes for essential foods and communities. Above all, the host community's perception on their living conditions has changed, and they were worried about their existence in their communities.

Place utility

The host community's essential services, like water and sanitation, health, and education, have deteriorated further due to Rohingya influx (Brothwell, 2018; Bark et al., 2018). As Rohingya camps are getting all attention in terms of health facilities, the host communities feel excluded as they have been facing a lack of health professionals, caregivers, medicines, and vaccines. All they get from the available healthcare facilities are tablets to remedy pain, cold, or fever. One female respondent of the host community of Tutir Bil village expressed,

“One day, my younger son was badly injured and broke his hand as he fell from the tree. My husband and I went to the nearest health complex and had a terrible experience. It was crowded with a huge number of Rohingya people, and we could not meet with the doctor, and then we had to go to Cox's Bazar Sadar Hospital, which is far away from our house and takes more than an hour to go. Before the Rohingyas were here, we had access to the local hospital's medical services” (I₉).

Further, access to regular education is one of the primary concerns of the host community for their children, as, after the Rohingya influx, teachers quit local primary schools and joined the 'Learning Center (LC) program' run for the Rohingya children in the camp for a higher salary. Also, local children have been facing problems in their schools. Besides, the child protection sub-sector reveals that the host community is suffering greatly from the vast traffic and trying to restrict their movement (Policy Research Institute, 2018; Banik, 2018). A female respondent at Palongkhali village said,

“We are now concerned about the future of our children. My adolescent girl cannot go to school due to eve-teasing and other issues that we did not face before the arrival of the Rohingya people” (I₁₄).

So parents are now very much concerned about their school-going children. Many children and adolescent girls stopped attending school due to massive traffic, eve-teasing and bad road conditions.

Place attachment

Rohingya influx directly affects the place attachment of the host communities. The place attachment indicates the non-human natural environment based on history, emotional response, or cognitive representation of people and place connections (Raymond et al., 2010). Items concerning nature bonding described the affiliation and connectedness with nature. A male community member of Purba Farir Bil village said,

"We are living here 7th generation. My father used to do agricultural activities here, I am also a farmer, but my main income comes from being a wood carpenter, my children receive education from the nearby school, and most of my relatives are living in different places in this Upazila. I never think of spending a single night outside of this place. This place represents me a lot and represents me" (I₄).

Most of the peoples' had the same reactions as he did; none wanted to leave this place permanently. However, they are now scared to face the disastrous situation made by a giant figure of Rohingya's involvement in their community. Actually, place attachment is a matter of their eternal satisfaction, which restricts them from migrating, given that there was lots of place in this country for better income sources. Their liberty and happiness being 'local', speaking the same language, sharing 'emotion', and being connected in every crisis, they feel secure in their place. A female respondent from Palongkhali village expressed as,

"We have a lot of issues in our locality after the Rohingya came. However, we cannot think of staying outside of our village. We have an excellent relationship with our neighbours that we will not have in another place" (I₁₂).

Whatever happens to their place, they can handle it jointly and hardly plan to move out because their places complete them with eternal happiness.

Place dependence

Place dependence refers to the essential functions of the place to the lives of the people living there, e.g. why the people live there, and what are the functional and goal-directed connections to the place for the people (Raymond et al., 2010). While discussing with the people living in Falia Para village of Raja Palong Union of Ukhia Upazila for FGD 1, it was evident that most people were involved in natural resource-based agriculture, fisheries, and forest sectors. Many of them were wood collectors as well as wood carpenters. Most of the FGD 1 participants were more than 50 years old. Thus, they were firmly attached to their places and highly dependent on them. Most of their livelihood activities depended on the surrounding environment. For example, wood collectors used to collect wood from a nearby forest, fishermen used to catch fish in nearby rivers or seas, and the farmer used to farm the farmlands surrounding their households. However, these activities have been hampered after the Rohingya influx. One of the male participants of the FGD 1 said,

"I used to collect wood from the nearby places for my carpentry shop. But now I do not get wood here, I have collected from far away. The number of trees has been drastically reduced after the Rohingya influx" (F₁).

Before the Rohingya influx, the host community's livelihood mainly depended on agriculture and a forest-based economy (NPM-ACAPS Analysis Hub, 2018; Save the Children, 2018). However, both options were drastically hampered due to the Rohingya influx. A male farmer who lives in Lambaghona village expressed,

"Our family has some agricultural land along with some Acacia trees. However, Rohingyas from the nearest camp regularly come to our land and collect bough from those trees" (I₂).

Very few from the host community could manage to engage in the business related to the supplies and services for the Rohingya humanitarian campaigns. In contrast, most of the communities lose the livelihood they were engaged in. Rohingyas reduced the labour price because they were ready to work at less than half the price of local wage demands since they received all basic household needs from the aid agencies, whereas host community people lacked those privileges. So for the host community, accommodating the local labour market was difficult, and their unemployment rate has gone all-time high. At the same time, the increasing trend of the price of necessary daily commodities impacted their livelihood and food consumption. A male day labourer of Dargah Bil village expressed that,

"Before the Rohingya came, we worked for a minimum 450/500 BDT per day, but now we are getting less payment, like 300/350 BDT after long bargaining. If we bargain more, then we cannot get the job, and the owner goes for the Rohingya labour as they are available and ready to work with the minimum payment. Again we could not buy our food sometimes because we had no work. You know the price of rice, potatoes, and oil has increased significantly since they came. I do not know how we can survive if it goes alike" (I₃).

As their livelihood radically changed and influenced their economic capability, they thought of alternative livelihood options. Some of the host community people stated that they need the support of capital, entrepreneurship training, and access to the market to make good use of their skills. Men were more interested in training in agriculture, farming technologies, and entrepreneurship, whereas women preferred traditional embroidery, pickle makings, home gardening, and caps and cloths making. Such changes in their livelihoods and daily lives reflect their place of obduracy.

Place identity

After the Rohingya influx host community faced several challenges in protecting their social and cultural identity. For instance, a

male shopkeeper in Kutupalong village expressed,

"Rohingya belong to a very conservative society, and they are insulting while behaving outside their community. They even ask me to give them free food and everything. If I say you are getting from the government, and they say I am a bad man. Can you imagine we are taking care of them, and they are telling us, terrible people?" (I₅).

It shows how the host community faces challenges in dealing with and tolerating the Rohingya community. The International Organization for Migration Bangladesh (IOM) revealed that since the massive influx in 2017, host communities have provided vital services and in-kind support to the Rohingya people and opened their homes as a shelter for the Rohingya people (IOM, 2018). At the beginning of the influx, host communities benefited from employing the newcomers for agriculture and other construction work. Still, within a few days, due to limited recourse like firewood, water and sanitation caused tensions between the Rohingya and the host community, which inflicted 'identity' issues for host communities. For instance, a male student of Sikdar Bil village expressed,

"At the beginning, we helped them (Rohingya people) and engaged them in work to help them, but within a few days, they (Rohingya) started to make their shelter on our land, but later on, it seems they treat them as a local, not we" (I₆).

Such a situation also created social tensions—disharmonizing social cohesion and influencing individual identities. An assessment by UNDP & UNWOMEN revealed that miscommunication is also a significant cause of social stress between Rohingya and the host community (UNDP Bangladesh and UN WOMEN Bangladesh, 2018). Host communities were also concerned about the rumours related to the Rohingya population. For example, the host community heard that the Rohingya engaged in crime and threatened the overall security in the neighbouring villages. An adolescent boy at Falia Para village said,

"My mother advised me not to talk with Rohingya people as they are ferocious, and if we meet closely with them, then we also get into trouble" (I₇).

While discussing with a male social worker of Purba Balukhali village, a member of the local "Balukhali Young Star Club", revealed that their family has a long history in their community. He was the 9th generation who cheers pleasant childhood memories and feels his identity as a local. He said,

"I grew up here watching farmers do agricultural activities; wood collector collects wood from the nearby forest, fisherman fish from the sea and river, and people from different region come here for business. The agricultural land, Forest, Sea, Rivers, Market, playground, School, College, and Mosque are all part of my existence. The people in this place are known to me; we use the same local language for communication, do similar activities, and have strong social bonding. These factors reflect my community and me. For me, this is the best living place, and no other place can be a substitute for this place. I feel relaxed and comfortable and find my real identity in this village. However, due to Rohingya involvement, I have also feared our existence" (I₈).

He and his fellow young friends in the community used to operate their "Young Star Club" and provided voluntary social services for their community, which was in non-function due to a significant number of unknown and unexpected Rohingya started living in their places in 2017. It was frustrating for them and destroyed their feelings as a local in this place. It was hard to find their real identity because of using a hybrid language (a mixture of the Chittagong local language, Bengali, and English), change in occupation, and social culture. So much involvement of Rohingya in social organizations threatened their place, identity, and existence. A male farmer at Telkhola village, Ukhia, said,

"This is my birthplace, my ancestors also lived here. The Rohingya people came here in 2017; now, their population is almost double due to their huge birth rate. We are feeling identity crisis and concerned that they will cover all our land in future" (I₁₃).

Place obduracy

As reported before, the Rohingya camps were built, deteriorating the forest, where the local community used to collect wood and fodders. Changes in both environment and society force people to combat the situation with unexpected and adopted strategies. For example, people who did share-cropping on their land constructed houses (tin-shed or buildings on agricultural land) to get more benefits to give these land to NGO's for their office or warehouse purpose of serving the Rohingya community. These have consequences on the local low-income farmers' livelihoods as they become vulnerable and change their land use, and they do not have enough land to go with the flow. The local community also claimed that the boat owner was hiring Rohingya labour instead of host community labour because of the low prices. The result was that the local low-income people became poorer than before.

Changes in their culture and rituals were reported. For instance, during focus group discussions, people reported that the rate of sexual harassment, bullying, safety, and security of women had been degraded after Rohingya entered their communities. Although the mobile court sometimes punishes the perpetrator, in most cases, the perpetrator hides in another camp. There was also an indication of increasing child marriage in their society after the Rohingya influxes, which also supported the findings of other studies conducted in host communities earlier in 2018 (NPM-ACAPS Analysis Hub, 2018).

However, there was evidence of the inclusion of Rohingyas into host communities through marriages between Bangladeshi and Rohingyas. While conducting an FGD 2 at Purba Farir Bil village of Palongkhali Union of Ukhia Upazila, the participants reported that some male persons from their (host) community got married to Rohingya women. At the same time, Rohingya men come to the host community for different purposes and engage in an illegal affairs with the host community women. One of the male FDG 2 participants revealed that.

“One of my cousins got engaged in an extramarital affair with one of the Rohingya women. Besides, there is also evidence of women from the host community are engaged in an extramarital affair with Rohingya men” (F₂).

These aspects of individual choices are not easy to explain; therefore, this study did not take them as a cultural amalgamation in general; instead, it keeps open as an integration process of the Rohingya into the Bangladeshi community.

Again, the Rohingya influx has adversely affected several protected areas of the host community, including gender-based violence (GBV), child protection, infrastructure, law, and order. Host community people are very much concerned over their locality's deteriorating law and order situation in the last year and a half. They stated that the incidents of GBV have increased at an alarming rate both in Rohingya and host communities. On their way to schools, markets, or homes, women, especially adolescent girls, were teased by Rohingya men. A teenage girl from Purba Balukhali village expressed that,

“I was regularly teased by some Rohingya men on the way to going to school or market, then I shared the consequence with my father, and he told me to stop going outside of the home” (I₁₀).

The theft and robbery incidents also drastically increased after the massive influx. No government agency, development worker, or even community people were not well-informed timely of the legal aspect of the Rohingya community. So most cases, the criminal could escape/avoid their punishment. So the threats of massive distraction still prevail in the host community.

To control the unauthorized exits or inclusion of Rohingya from the camps, the government of Bangladesh established several check posts in the catchment area of the camp. Previously, host community people could move without checking, but now they require the National Identity Card (NID) while moving around. A small businessman at Kutupalong Bazar said,

“After the Rohingya influx, we have to carry our NID with us all the time, and it is really disgusting when we forget to bring it and are harassed by the Army in the check post and that time they treat us as Rohingya, and this is really painful. I am unsatisfied with how the situation is going on here. I may leave this place with my family shortly, as our local leader is not protecting our demands. Rather they are focusing on Rohingya issues, as they have more monetary benefit keeping the Rohingya in Kutupalong” (I₁₁).

Such observations on the local political situations raised questions about the local community people's security and livelihood satisfaction.

Discussion and outlook

Implications of the study

The rapid arrival of Rohingya refugees since August 2017 has been a significant shock to a local community that already experiences underemployment, under-investment, and poor access to services as challenges to development. Also, after that, the host communities have been confronting significant challenges. Some pressings, incurring, and emerging concerns are social tensions, economic changes, cultural challenges, safety, security, and massive environmental degradation. Due to such differences in the environmental conditions, the host community people need to change their livelihoods; for example, people left farming and constructed makeshift settlements for Rohingya's living (Ansar & Khaled, 2021; Ullah et al., 2021).

This paper provides valuable insights to national and international policymakers regarding the hosting of refugees and relevant policy formulation. In the humanitarian ground, providing shelter to the refugees is essential. However, it is important to consider all the consequences for the host communities. This paper shows how the place relations of people have been impacted in different contexts that may take (i) the attention of the policymakers for ensuring co-existence and co-governance of the crisis, (ii) further research endeavours to investigate the residential satisfaction of both refugee and host-communities despite different livelihood challenges.

All the host communities' social, cultural, economic, and environmental situations directly affected their relations with their living place. The overall comfort of living in such a socioeconomic environment became lower, and the host communities became vulnerable and worried about the surrounding circumstances. The compassion shown by the local community was exemplary at the beginning of the exodus. Now it seems to have turned into fury, occasionally expressed by the host community through processions and human chains. But the present situation shows that social bonding had slowly broken down due to Rohingya people being denied to leave the land, which the host community gave when the influx started. The security and safety question for their children has also been worsened. People belonging to the host community have been facing significant price hikes for regular commodities, scarcity of transport, and traffic congestion. Besides, the degradation of the environment, including hill cutting, deforestation, security issues, and health services, are significant outcomes of the Rohingya influx. Hence, it is crucial to holistically assess all these social, political, economic, and environmental factors related to livelihood satisfaction to find a standard mechanism that addresses the humanitarian activities for the Rohingyas and includes the livelihood satisfaction of the host communities. However, the host community enjoys some benefits from the Rohingya refugees, such as buying relief goods that have food items (rice, pulses, and oil) and sanitary products (soap, detergents, and so on) at a lower price. The Rohingya refugees sell excessive relief goods to the local people they receive from humanitarian organizations. Due to more people in the area, some local businessmen have been getting benefits, for instance, owners of hotels and restaurants. But the benefits are significantly less than the sufferings of the people there.

The immeasurable human suffering and safety issues for children, adolescents, and women in the Rohingya and host communities are exposed to high levels of violence, abuse, and exploitation, including sexual harassment, child labour, and child marriage. An environmental disaster like a landslide pretends to be familiar if high rainfall happens. Some critical impacts are likely irreversible if no

measure takes place instantaneously.

Limitations of the study and further explorations

This research has some limitations. Most of the respondents of the study are male. It was impossible to include more female respondents due to the conservative nature of the society, although it was planned to have 40% female respondents in this study. Besides, most females in the community did not want to speak out. A further empirical assessment of the relations to place and residential satisfaction not only for host communities but also for Rohingyas will explore how to bridge the gap between the Rohingyas and host communities. And it will then prove the efficacy of the massive humanitarian activities for Rohingyas, thus degrading the livelihood satisfaction of the host communities. Last but not least, governments and policymakers should emphasize the co-existence and co-governance initiatives, so that both the host and Rohingya communities can stay together as long as the return of Rohingyas to Myanmar is not taken place.

Ethical concern

This research followed the ethical principles of the Helsinki Declaration. The purpose of the study was explained to the respondents, and consent was taken before the interview. The respondents had the right to quit the interview at any time. The real identity of the study participants is not used anywhere in the study.

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Consent has been taken before conducting the interview.

Consent for publication

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Conflict of interest

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